

Retrospective on Issue-Centric Organizing Effort

The Starkville Community's Response to the 2026 Cryptomining Facility Project

During the period of late June to early August of 2026 (about 2 months), local residents in Starkville and the surrounding area organized a group opposed to a cryptocurrency mining facility proposed for construction in the city. That effort had the intended impact, as the facility was denied by the Planning and Zoning commission on August 11, and the proposing company pulled their own special exemption request application from consideration before the subsequent Board of Aldermen meeting.

This document is an attempt to summarize the organizing techniques and tactics used in that effort to provide some level of insight and guidance for other potential organizers and caring community members that are driven to work on future efforts in our area.

September 13, 2026

1. Purpose

I intend for this document to serve as a post-event analysis report on what was done during this work (from my perspective and those I get feedback from) for the benefit of myself, my fellow local organizers, other organizers-to-be, and the community at large.

This document may serve as a potential list of dos and don'ts for others looking to make similar organizational efforts in Starkville, or maybe even perhaps municipalities in general that are similar to our own (e.g., small, college town, population likely to engage in efforts like this)¹.

Finally, I am writing this because I was asked to, and I like to be helpful.

1.1. Contact Info

My name is Dalton Winans-Pruitt, and if you care enough about work to contact me, you can probably find me by asking certain people around town. However, I'm not putting any personal phone number or email in a document I intend to make public.

I will leave this email, though I don't guarantee I'll check it often: starkvillecmf@gmail.com

1.2. Timeline

I originally had a section on the timeline of this issue, but I realized that the exact timeline is not really important for a few reasons:

1. Every situation is different; the timelines will differ, sometimes drastically, between different companies, local governments, and local communities. Why our timeline worked may not apply.
2. The order of these steps isn't super relevant. The point is that we organized and organized (somewhat) effectively, not that we held some certain number of meetings within a certain amount of time, or sent a certain amount of messages.
3. Organizing is more "fuzzy" than most problems I usually work on. With my engineering background, I'm used to following a certain list of steps when troubleshooting an issue or working on a solution to a problem. These efforts were most certainly not like that, but I believe the general insights we offer below may help offer guidance!

If you are interested in a timeline of big events, you can see the timeline on website^o, but this timeline is from before the P&Z meeting on 2026-08-11 and has not been updated since then. For anyone still interested in a more detailed play-by-play, I may be able to provide a timeline of key organizational events later.

2. Why Did This Work?

Another resident and myself collaborated on the following list of what happened here that

¹There are likely many more aspects of our town that are different to others, such as percentage that are college-educated, percentage of households with children, percentage of households beneath the poverty line, etc. I don't know which dimensions we are higher or lower in, and I don't know exactly how it would impact efforts like these. Ultimately, I believe social cohesion is the best indicator of the success of efforts like this, but I don't know exactly how to measure that...

we believe helped the community reach this outcome². This list is not exhaustive, and more could be revealed from further discussions, but I wanted to get *something* out to people and not ruminate on this forever!

This is broken down into two main parts: things we could control, and things we could not control:

- Things We Could Control
 - Attending local government events
 - Speaking up
 - Research
 - Communication
 - Divide-and-conquer
 - In-person meetings
 - Empathizing with your opposition
 - Over-preparing
- Things We Could Not Control
 - The specifics that made this project such a contentious one
 - Our local government structure, rules, and sentiments
 - Existing connections between people

The order of these is slightly arbitrary, but as some of these are more important than others (at least subjectively), I have tried to order them in more important to least important, at least for the “things we could control” section. All of these are discussed in more detail below.

2.1. Things We Could Control

2.1.1. Attending Local Government Meetings

While the “big” meetings (the ones relevant to this issue), were super important to encourage attendance to (and preparation beforehand), there are also regularly scheduled meetings in the city that you may now know about, likely thanks either to a number of people putting the word out about this issue or to recent awareness campaigns on Facebook pages such as Starkville Voices and The Civic Blueprint.

Very few residents regularly attend the normally-scheduled^o government meetings, such as Board of Aldermen meetings (1st and 3rd Tuesdays, work sessions on Fridays before regular meetings) and Planning and Zoning Commission meetings (more irregular, but can check the same calendar^o), or other civic events, such as Town Halls (find on Facebook or other social media; not required for city to notify public if not a certain number of city officials present). This lack of attendance is, in large part, justified by the fact that most of the discussions by the city staff and office holders are not relevant to most residents, at least not more relevant than whatever plans the residents may normally have on those days.

Due to this, a large portion of the processes of the local government are not clear to the residents, leading to a supposed lack of transparency due to ignorance. Not willful ignorance, but just a state of not knowing due to lack of experience. These gaps in one’s knowledge could

²While we believe this result was in the best interest of the community, others may disagree. Ultimately, the city is meant to follow the will of the people within it, and we believed the will just needed to “speak up” a bit more in this case.

be filled in through attendance at a small number of the aforementioned regular city meetings. An understanding of the structure of the meetings allows one to voice their concerns at the right time, to the right people, and with the right tonality³.

Knowing which meetings could be relevant to you requires vigilance as to what topics are being discussed, then choosing which meetings to attend based on those topics. I was notified of this specific issue through a Commercial Dispatch article shared to me by a member of a local tech-focused group. This is one of the main purposes of the press, but you can't rely on a third party to know what you care about and surface it to you. I don't have a good solution for this other than remembering to read through the agendas posted to the agenda website. They also may post it physically at city hall, but I am unsure.

In any case, our attendance before the "important" meetings (i.e. where decisions were made) was crucial for our effort, as not only did we learn how the processes normally work and asked for more information, but we also met other concerned residents and started discussing next steps pretty early on in the process.

2.1.2. Speaking Up

Without the several people speaking up at the first couple Board of Aldermen meetings, we would not have found each other and began making plans. Without those plans, there most certainly would have been fewer people in the know about this topic, and fewer people would have showed up at the Planning and Zoning Commission meeting.

Being the first to speak up can be hard, especially when you're not trained or experienced. And super especially when those you are speaking in front of are the decision-makers of your city of residence. I am not a good public speaker, in that I have a weird fight/flight/freeze response to going up to the podium. But I got up there, mentioned one concern I saw that hadn't been asked yet, and then "I would like to be put on the list to be in those conversations." In retrospect, it wasn't hard, but it seems impossible when you've never made the effort to do something like that before. Putting yourself out there in public is intimidating for many people.

So, if you don't want to do it live on camera (reasonably so), then please take the time to find people of similar minds on whatever social media you are on. I wholeheartedly believe that if you are sincere in trying to help the community, you will find people that will help you. There will be people that want to be rude or hurtful, but they are likely just jealous of the future that you are trying to help build. If they had to suffer through something, why doesn't everyone else? This isn't an all-encompassing viewpoint, but keeping that in mind may help you get through the 5-10% of comments that are rude.⁴

This section could technically be lumped in with "Communications", but I believe it is important to distinguish the initial public voicing of concerns from the continued discussion amongst a group.

³Ignorance leads to fear, fear leads to anger, and anger is met with more anger and resistance. It is easier to catch flies with honey than with vinegar. Insert some other adage about being nice to others.

⁴Also, please note that I am not saying everyone that disagrees with you is just trying to stifle your efforts. They may be just as sincere in their beliefs that what you're doing is impossible. And if you find that most of the comments you are receiving are negative, maybe double-check that your original comments/post wasn't just you complaining about something instead of asking questions or offering solutions.

2.1.3. Research

A large part of our effort surrounding this issue was our research on various topics. Some of the topics included:

- The company(ies) tied to this proposed facility; any apparent company names, project names, etc. – we found the relevant LLCs
- Existing sites by the same company – we found out through public records how the company operated in their other stated location
- Similar sites throughout the country – we found common concerns/issues amongst a variety of sites (noise, light, etc.)
- How the Special Exception zoning process works in our city – this helped us know when and where to show up for the most impact, since this facility needed a Special Exception zoning permit. Your local government rules may differ here, but you basically need to convince the person in charge of approving the construction.

This research was done in a fairly unstructured manner. No specified format was required or requested; there wasn't even a shared repository location aside from one long document containing speeches we worked on (most of which were never even used). Instead, information was shared in our various group chats (mostly one large chat with subgroups). Several types of information were shared:

- official documents from government sources,
- news articles,
- our own written words,
- and other sources/repositories of information.

The act of doing the research prepared us to make well-structured, fact-based arguments that hit on the biggest concerns the residents had. Knowing is half the battle.

2.1.4. Continued Communication

Several people were listing to various social media websites about this topic. Facebook and Nextdoor were the main ones I was personally aware of, but there were at least a few established private groups where this was brought up; the tech meetup group was where I heard about it first.

Around mid-July, a group chat was created for this specific topic, on GroupMe, to be precise. The topics feature was ver helpful, as it allowed us to have multiple conversations happening at once about different topics. Even so, just the main general chat was good to have to spread information about our research, potential arguments, relevant meetings, and other info.

Consistent communication is important in any relationship, whether it be friends, significant others, teams, employment, and, in our case, civic engagement groups.

2.1.5. In-Person Meetings

The asynchronous communication of group chats is very useful, but nothing builds morale and camaraderie quite like meeting in-person. As most know, humans are social creatures, and we gain a lot of understanding of others from interacting in real-time in-person. Speech patterns and tones, unedited stream of consciousness discussion, and body language all play

into our social experiences, and I think those play crucial parts in developing the relationships that enable us to be effective.

This is coming from someone that studied and worked from home for about 3 years. There's nothing quite like sharing a space with people working towards a shared cause.

2.1.6. Divide-and-Conquer

No individual could wield the time and energy to attend meetings, perform research, and write speeches all with enough quality to sway the decision makers. One of the key parts of the community's success in this work was our ability to split up the work. Most of us were concerned about multiple issues, but by focusing on the one or two issues and collaborating through collating findings, we were able to amass a large amount of relevant information that helped our cause.

This may have been obvious to those that participated in this effort, and is probably obvious to anyone that has participated in an organization (business, government, nonprofit, etc.) as an individual contributor or manager. However, I think it is important to state so that those involved in future work do not take it for granted. If others aren't willing to do the work with you, you will burn yourself out⁵ AND you will likely not achieve what you want. Some of us felt burnt out after our efforts, so I know that if it was just one or two of us involved, there's no way we could have gotten this done.

2.1.7. Empathizing with Your Opposition

I think we all know a way to make a debate easier is to know more than your interlocutor on the subject, both about your own views and about where theirs may be based. Going through the stated and theoretical arguments you may run into is a worthwhile exercise to help you develop your own reasoning and arguments⁵. We attempted to at least list the arguments in favor of the facility on the website⁶.

One term concerning this is "steelmanning", or attempting to address the strongest version of your opponent's argument, essentially the opposite of "strawmanning". I believe that many of us tried to do this, though it likely could have been more effective had we had clear roles to fill in a sort of fake debate/argument setting. Putting the arguments through the metaphorical fire could help figure out which ones are worth keeping.

Also, I personally believe it is important to empathize with your opposition because you may find common ground and even possibly could arrive at a third alternative⁶. We are just all humans, even if we disagree on what is "best".

2.1.8. Over-Preparing

You can't really know how much is the "right" amount of prepared⁷, but we preferred to be over-prepared than under-prepared. Specifically, I believe we overprepared our arguments and our gathering of people.

⁵I even personally changed my mind on a few items after going through this exercise.

⁶Look, I've been reading a lot of self-help books and recently took a negotiation course. While this is a bit of woo-woo, I do believe that people at least trying to cooperate can come to unique solutions to problems that neither would have figured out on their own!

⁷We were also fairly lucky in that the business proposing the facility was very underprepared, at least for the level of pushback the community showed here. This may or may not be the main reason I feel "overprepared".

I mentioned above that we had multiple speeches prepared that didn't even get used. However, the preparation of every speech led to better preparedness. We did **a lot** of reading, writing, and talking about the issue. Every argument made and every fact found was a new tool in our toolbelt. Wouldn't you rather have too many tools than not enough?

Well, some would say that having too many can lead to analysis paralysis, but that's why you leave some tools at home when you go to the jobsite. You gather tools over time at home or work, acknowledge the ones you will most likely need or make use of in the coming day, pack those tools, and go to the jobsite with only the most potentially useful tools. I may have let the metaphor get away from me, but I hope it is clear that having more information and arguments means that we were better able to evaluate at a higher level which ones were worth keeping.

As to the gathering of people, over 80 people showed up to the first public hearing at the Planning and Zoning Commission meeting on 8/11/2026^o. There were even over 20 people standing. Only 10 residents had time to speak during the 15 minute time allotment given during the public hearing, but it was clear what the vast majority of residents were present for and which side they stood on.

Technically, maybe this would have been successful with only 50 people, or maybe even just 30 and a list. But the large showing was instrumental in demonstrating that, for one reason or another, the city's residents did not want this center here.

Again, you would rather be overprepared than underprepared, and you don't know how much is "over".

2.2. Things We Could Not Control

2.2.1. This Specific Issue

Data centers are currently in the national spotlight due to things like "artificial intelligence". Cryptocurrency as well is a hot topic for some groups.

In addition, this proposed facility would have been located pretty centrally to the city (see here^o for pictures^o), meaning it potentially would impact many different groups, including businesses, animals, and businesses. It was less than 1/10th of a mile from the Oktibbeha County Humane Society and just across the street from the Academy of Competitive and Performing Arts.

I believe that this basically led to a kind of "perfect storm" of opposition to the project, including:

- those concerned with resource usage locally and impacts to utilities bills,
- those that oppose crypto currency on a moral or other basis,
- those concerned about potential noise impacts to animals and wildlife,
- those that are concerned about the power usage from an environmental standpoint (emissions from power generation),
- people concerned with the obfuscated ownership structure of the project, and

^oThis website may be deactivated by the time you read this, but you can find more information out if you care. You could email starkvillecmf@gmail.com or you could ask whoever you got this from for more info if needed.

- those that are concerned about the usage of capacity of the substation for cryptocurrency instead of other industries that provide services or produce physical goods.

These parties spanned political parties, religions, and other dimensions we are so typically divided. This broad support for our cause (opposition to the project) led to overwhelming numbers at the Planning and Zoning Commission. Without the organization of people and speeches beforehand, I would bet that there still would have been more people present to oppose the project than the number that are normally present at the Planning and Zoning Commission or Board of Aldermen meetings.

It may not have been as overwhelming of a response if the organizing had not have occurred, but we wanted to point out how this specific issue itself was such an almost toxic topic in and of itself that the community would have still done something else to organize before the Board of Aldermen meeting at least.

2.2.2. Our Local Government Structure, Rules, and Sentiments

Technically, in the long term, the citizens have control over how the local government is structured. At least, we do as long as we have democratically-elected decision makers that are amenable to change.

However, in the 2-3 month time frame we are normally dealing with issues, as in this case, we must work within the system of which we are a part. Arguments can be made about soft power and slightly nudging the levers of the system to behave a bit differently, but those are hard to find, harder to weild, and could potentially work against you. So, it is probably best to stick to the normal systems in place and learn them inside and out.

2.2.3. Existing Connections Between People

For better or worse, many of us did not know each other at the beginning of our work on this issue. Hearing each other speak and participate in the initial Board of Aldermen meeting and the July town hall were the first time many of us had ever interacted. However, being united ideologically on this issue allowed us to quickly come together and work towards our desired outcome, or at least to work towards a better understanding.

As mentioned above, it took a “village” to do this work and change our predicted situation. But that village does not just appear; it has to be built up, either in the moment through almost desparate efforts to reach out to each other or far in advance, slowly enough to build actual rapport between members. The more slowly built-up connections are harder to break and fade, as they become stronger than passing acquaintances.

If all of us had simply waited for someone else to speak up, no one would know who to talk to.

- Many of us did not already know each other, but we were able to come together to work towards a common goal
- It took a village to create change in our situation. People will need to speak out publicly about the issue and/or network with those who are also concerned

3. Things to Do Before “Next Time”

By “next time”, I don’t mean another cryptomining facility, but rather any kind of perceived community crises that requires many voices to come together.

Maybe the next issue to tackle is the fact that many people are being priced out of the city.

Maybe it’s that many kids in our county face food insecurity anytime they’re not in school.

Maybe it’s the perceived lack of “things to do” for our families and youth.

I don’t know how best any issues should be tackled, but I do know that the more people discuss them and decide to cooperate with each other, the better the chances of an issue being worked on.

As I’ve stated before here, doing things early was important.

“The best time to plant a tree was 20 years ago; the second best time is today.”

We should all work on “planting more trees”, and this is done by growing your connections within the community, thereby strengthening the community itself.

3.1. Find Caring People Within Your Institutions / Join a Civic Engagement Group

By “institution” here, I mean schools, churches and other religious organizations, non-profits, and other non-government and non-business organizations you may be a part of. People in an organization with you already have a connection to you, and if you find out they would be willing to help out with efforts like this in the future, you could both join a civic engagement group together, such as Working Together Mississippi (there’s a chapter in Starkville/ Oktibbeha county), Better Together, or another. Or maybe start one of your own if you find enough people willing to help on a specific class of issues⁹.

Alternatively, there are some groups dedicated specifically to encouraging civic engagement, regardless of issue. Look around and ask about these, as well!

3.2. Have More Small Community Events

There are tons of community events happening in Starkville. The main regular one that comes to mind is the Community Market during the spring/summer/early fall months at Firestation Park. However, events like that are often too large to really have small conversations; I personally like events with 5-15 people, because then you can have pretty intimate conversations without worrying about missing out on what 4 other groups are talking about. Of course, this may be me projecting, but we should honestly just have more events of various types and sizes.

The main obstacle to having more of these is probably cost; venue and food alone can amount to a decent amount of money if you don’t have funding. However, you can often crowd-source these costs by making the event a potluck (if during a time people normally would eat anyways) and potentially finding an insitution with a meeting area they may let you

⁹From training with Working Together Mississippi, it is encouraged not to form organizations around specific issues, as those organizations often don’t survive past the resolution surrounding the relevant issue/ topic (for various reasons). However, if this is the only way to get someone invovled, it’s better than not doing anything.

use at reduced cost or even free. These are the two things we did for our in-person meeting before the P&Z meeting, and it worked very nicely.

Ultimately, I think more community events could lead to a more cohesive and understanding community, and, while that is a nice goal in and of itself, it would lead to better responses to important community issues.

3.3. Set Up System for Checking Public Meeting Agendas Ahead of Time

There is sort of a system in place if you count the news media interpreting what is important for the community. But if you want something more specific to your own institutions or other parts of the community, then you would need some kind of specialized system that would check the agendas and look for things that would be more relevant to your group.

For example, there could be a small team of people that would take turns looking through the items on the agenda, then summarizing for a broader audience or altering specific subgroups of anything of pertinence to them. This is a very manual approach, but may be necessary for human interpretation to add value. Alternatively, a more automated system could check for new agendas, read the text from the agenda files, then check the words for a specific set of keywords set by your group/institution. This is much less hands-on, but it may not catch cases where word choices may deviate from the given list of keywords. It still could be useful to look into, however.

4. Conclusion

- Do things as early as is responsible¹⁰
- Talk to people. In-person. Online, too, but especially in-person.
- Don't be afraid to do the leg work of research.
- Be sure to split the load with others.

¹⁰For example: DO try to find people to help you early; DON'T try to hire a lawyer to help before you've even done an hour of research.